

*Haligric Research Integration Series*

# JAINISM

## A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

*Ahimsa, Anekantavada, Aparigraha — The Most Radical Ethics in Human History*

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*The most radical ethical tradition in human history.  
A tradition that extends non-violence to every living being —  
to the microorganism crushed underfoot,  
to the water that holds life,  
to the truth held by the person who disagrees with you.  
"Micchami Dukkadam."  
May all the evil I have done be undone.*

# Contents

|                                                                   |    |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------|----|
| Introduction — The Oldest Living Ethical Tradition.....           | 3  |
| Jain Origins and History.....                                     | 4  |
| The Tirthankaras — The 24 Ford-Makers.....                        | 5  |
| Mahavira — The Twenty-Fourth and Final Tirthankara.....           | 6  |
| Jain Metaphysics — The Nature of Reality.....                     | 7  |
| The Jiva and the Ajiva — Soul and Non-Soul.....                   | 8  |
| Karma in Jain Understanding — The Most Complete Karma Theory..... | 9  |
| Ahimsa — The Foundational Cosmological Principle.....             | 10 |
| The Hierarchy of Sentient Beings.....                             | 11 |
| Anekantavada — The Many-Sidedness of Truth.....                   | 12 |
| Syadvada — The Seven-Fold Logic.....                              | 13 |
| Nayavada — The Doctrine of Partial Perspectives.....              | 14 |
| Aparigraha — Non-Possession as Liberation.....                    | 15 |
| The Five Great Vows (Mahavratas).....                             | 16 |
| The Three Jewels — Samyak Jnana, Darshana, Charitra.....          | 17 |
| The Digambara and Shvetambara Traditions.....                     | 18 |
| The Fourteen Gunasthanas — Stages of Spiritual Development.....   | 19 |
| The Jain Monk and Nun — Life of Total Commitment.....             | 20 |
| The Jain Layperson — The Anuvrats.....                            | 21 |
| Sallekhana — The Sacred Fast unto Death.....                      | 22 |
| Paryushana and Samvatsari — The Annual Sacred Period.....         | 23 |
| Jain Sacred Texts — The Agamas.....                               | 24 |
| Jain Cosmology — The Universe Without a Creator.....              | 25 |
| Jain Sacred Art and Architecture.....                             | 26 |
| Gandhi and Jain Influence on the World.....                       | 27 |
| The Haligricity Lens — Anekantavada and Ahimsa as Practice.....   | 28 |

# Introduction

## The Oldest Living Ethical Tradition

Jainism is among the oldest living religious traditions in the world — an independent Indian tradition with roots that predate the historical Mahavira (6th century BCE), contemporaneous with early Buddhism and the Vedic tradition in the same cultural milieu but completely distinct from both. Its foundational insights represent the most radical, most consistent, and most philosophically sophisticated application of the ethical recognition of the sanctity of life available in any tradition anywhere.

The three foundational Jain principles — Ahimsa (non-violence toward every living being), Anekantavada (no single perspective captures the whole of reality), and Aparigraha (non-possession as liberation from wanting) — are not merely ethical recommendations. They are the practical applications of the most complete ancient account of the nature of consciousness, karma, and liberation that any tradition has produced. This guide covers all of it: the metaphysics, the cosmology, the karma theory, the philosophical logic of Anekantavada, the specific practices of the monks and laypersons, the sacred texts, the tradition's extraordinary influence on the wider world through Gandhi and the global nonviolent resistance tradition.

Jainism has between 4 and 6 million followers worldwide, concentrated primarily in India (approximately 4.5 million per the 2011 census, concentrated in Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Gujarat, and Madhya Pradesh), with a diaspora of approximately 250,000-300,000 outside India — primarily in the United States (~80,000-150,000), United Kingdom (~25,000-30,000), Kenya (~68,000), and Belgium (~2,000, concentrated in the Antwerp diamond trade). Despite their small numbers, Jains have exercised an influence on Indian culture, philosophy, art, law, and commerce wildly disproportionate to their size — a fact directly attributable to the tradition's specific ethical principles.

## Jain Origins and History

Jainism's origins extend further back than the historical Mahavira. The tradition holds that in each cosmic half-cycle, 24 Tirthankaras (ford-makers — those who create a crossing point from the cycle of rebirth to liberation) appear and teach the eternal path. Rishabhanatha, the first Tirthankara of the current cycle, is placed at the very beginning of the current cosmic era.

The 23rd Tirthankara, Parshvanatha (approximately 872-772 BCE), is the earliest Tirthankara for whom there is possible archaeological and textual evidence. He is credited with establishing the four major vows (Ahimsa, Satya, Asteya, Aparigraha) — Mahavira added the fifth (Brahmacharya) and systematized the teaching. The existence of Parshvanatha as a pre-Mahavira Jain teacher is acknowledged by Buddhist texts, making Jainism one of the few traditions that has pre-founder documentation from an independent source.

Jainism is not a reform movement within Hinduism — it has its own cosmology, its own understanding of the soul, its own karma theory, and its own path to liberation that are structurally different from both Hindu and Buddhist frameworks. It rejects the authority of the Vedas, the caste system, and the existence of a creator God. The Jain universe is eternal and uncreated. Both Jainism and Buddhism emerged from the same 6th-century BCE Indian intellectual ferment — the Shramana tradition that challenged the dominant Vedic ritualism with more interior, more ethical, and more experiential approaches to the sacred.

# The Tirthankaras

## The 24 Ford-Makers

Tirthankara (from Sanskrit: "ford-maker" or "crossing-maker") refers to the 24 enlightened beings who in each cosmic cycle achieve perfect knowledge and teach the path to liberation — making a ford across the ocean of worldly existence through which others can cross. They are not gods in the Hindu sense — they do not create or sustain the universe, do not answer prayers, and have no further relationship with the material world after their liberation. They are the highest possible attainment of the human soul: beings who have eliminated all karma, achieved omniscience, and shown the path by which every other soul can follow.

The Tirthankaras are distinguished from ordinary liberated souls (Siddhas) by the specific role they play during their final embodied life — they teach, they establish the fourfold community (monks, nuns, laymen, laywomen), and they provide the specific path for their cosmic era. The five auspicious events (Pancha Kalyanaka) in every Tirthankara's life are venerated: conception, birth, renunciation, omniscience (kevala jnana), and final liberation (moksha). These five events are the primary occasions of Jain devotional practice and the basis for the most significant Jain ceremonies.

The first Tirthankara of the current cosmic cycle is Rishabhanatha (also called Adinath — "the first Lord"), who is credited in Jain tradition with founding civilization itself — teaching humanity agriculture, arts, crafts, writing, and the social institutions that made organized human life possible. The last Tirthankara before the current age of decline was Arishtanemi (Neminath), the 22nd, traditionally identified as a cousin of the Hindu god Krishna. The 23rd was Parshvanatha, and the 24th and last Tirthankara of this cosmic cycle was Mahavira.

# Mahavira

## The Twenty-Fourth and Final Tirthankara

Mahavira (the Great Hero — born Vardhamana, approximately 599-527 BCE in Vaishali, northern India, now Bihar) was the 24th and final Tirthankara of the current cosmic cycle. He was born into the warrior-noble class (Kshatriya), the son of a Jain chieftain — already indicating that the Jain tradition Mahavira was born into had a significant pre-existing presence. His father was a follower of Parshvanatha's tradition.

At the age of 30, Mahavira renounced his comfortable life, abandoned his clothing (in the Digambara account he was never married; in the Shvetambara account he had a wife and daughter whom he left), and entered a life of total renunciation. For twelve and a half years he practiced extreme austerities — total non-violence (he walked barefoot to avoid crushing insects, strained water to avoid swallowing water-organisms, brushed the ground before sitting), total silence, total indifference to the physical conditions of his body (heat, cold, insects, abuse from passersby). He did not bathe, did not protect himself, did not seek comfort.

At approximately age 42, in the state of deep meditation under a sala tree near the town of Jrimbhikagrama, Mahavira attained kevala jnana — omniscience, the complete and unlimited knowledge of all things at all times. He spent the remaining 30 years of his life teaching, establishing the fourfold community (monks, nuns, laymen, laywomen), and systematizing the Jain path. He taught in the Ardhamagadhi language — the vernacular of his region — making his teachings accessible to all, not restricted to Brahmin Sanskrit scholars. At the age of 72 he attained final liberation (moksha) at Pavapuri in Bihar, entering the Siddha Loka permanently.

Mahavira was a contemporary of the Buddha — they preached in the same region of northeastern India at approximately the same time, and Buddhist texts mention encounters and debates with Mahavira's followers (whom they call "Niganthas" — the unattached ones). The two traditions share significant common ground (rejection of Vedic authority, emphasis on non-violence, the monastic community as the heart of the tradition) while differing profoundly in their metaphysics (Jainism maintains the eternal, individual soul; Buddhism denies the permanent self).

# Jain Metaphysics

## The Nature of Reality

Jain metaphysics is among the most complete and most rigorously consistent in any philosophical tradition. Unlike traditions that leave fundamental metaphysical questions vague or mysterious, Jainism provides precise, detailed, internally consistent accounts of the nature of souls, matter, space, time, and the principles that govern their interactions.

## The Six Dravyas (Fundamental Substances)

**JIVA (Soul/Consciousness):** The living principle — individual, eternal, self-luminous consciousness. Each jiva is unique, uncreated, and in its pure state omniscient and infinitely capable.

**PUDGALA (Matter):** The non-conscious physical substance — composed of atoms, capable of forming complex structures, the material through which karma operates on the soul.

**AKASHA (Space):** The medium in which all other substances exist.

**KALA (Time):** The serial process of change — Jain cosmology has an elaborate account of time as both infinite and cyclically structured.

**DHARMA (Medium of Motion):** Not the ethical principle but a specific metaphysical substance — the medium that enables movement. Without the dharma dravya, nothing could move.

**ADHARMA (Medium of Rest):** The complementary substance — the medium that enables rest. Without adharma dravya, nothing could stop. The dharma/adharma dravyas are unique to Jain metaphysics — no other tradition has proposed specific metaphysical substances to explain the conditions of movement and rest.

# The Jiva and the Ajiva

## Soul and Non-Soul — The Fundamental Division

The most fundamental distinction in Jain metaphysics is between jiva (soul, the living, the conscious) and ajiva (non-soul, the non-living, the non-conscious). Every possible entity in the universe falls into one of these two categories — nothing is both and nothing is neither.

Every jiva, in its pure unobstructed state, possesses four infinite qualities: infinite knowledge (ananta jnana), infinite perception (ananta darshana), infinite bliss (ananta sukha), and infinite power (ananta virya). These infinite qualities are obscured in all non-liberated jivas by the accumulation of karma — the specific karmic matter (karma pudgala) that adheres to the soul through its actions and determines its specific capacities in each life. Every jiva — from the soul of a microorganism to the soul of a human being to the souls of the Tirthankaras — is fundamentally equal in its intrinsic nature. The differences between beings are the differences in their karmic accumulation, not in their essential nature. This is the metaphysical foundation of Jain ahimsa: every living being carries a divine soul equal in its intrinsic nature to every other.

The jiva's journey is through samsara (the cycle of birth and death across different bodies — plant, insect, animal, human, divine) until the complete elimination of karma makes moksha (liberation) possible. In moksha, the jiva rises to the top of the universe (the Siddha Loka) and remains there in infinite bliss and omniscience, never returning to the cycle.



# Karma in Jain Understanding

## The Most Complete Karma Theory

The Jain theory of karma is the most detailed and most mechanically precise karma theory in any tradition — specifying eight types of karma, each with specific functions, specific durations, and specific conditions for their exhaustion. Unlike Hindu karma (often understood as a general moral accounting system) or Buddhist karma (more focused on intention as the determinative factor), Jain karma is treated as a specific category of subtle physical matter that literally adheres to the soul.

## Ghatiya Karma (Destructive Karma — directly destroys the soul's inherent qualities)

- 1. Jnanavaraniya Karma:** Knowledge-obscuring karma — obscures the soul's inherent omniscience. The greater the knowledge-obscuring karma, the less knowledge the being has.
- 2. Darshanavarniya Karma:** Perception-obscuring karma — obscures the soul's inherent infinite perception.
- 3. Mohaniya Karma:** Delusion-producing karma — the most important and most dangerous type. Mohaniya karma produces delusion about the nature of the soul and about what constitutes right conduct. It is the root of all the other karmas' accumulation.
- 4. Antaraya Karma:** Obstruction karma — creates obstacles to the exercise of the soul's inherent infinite power, particularly to giving, receiving, and enjoyment.

## Aghatiya Karma (Non-Destructive Karma — determines conditions of embodied existence)

- 5. Nama Karma:** Body-determining karma — determines the specific form, body type, and physical characteristics of the next birth.
- 6. Gotra Karma:** Status-determining karma — determines the social and family status of the birth.
- 7. Ayushya Karma:** Lifespan karma — determines the duration of the next life.
- 8. Vedniya Karma:** Feeling-producing karma — determines the types of pleasure and pain experienced in the life.

# Ahimsa

## The Foundational Cosmological Principle

Ahimsa (non-violence, non-harm, harmlessness) is the foundational principle of Jainism — and in the Jain tradition, it is not merely an ethical recommendation or a social contract. It is the direct practical application of the Jain metaphysical recognition that every living being is a soul (jiva) equal in its intrinsic nature to every other soul, including one's own. Violence toward any being is therefore simultaneously a moral wrong (it harms a being that is, in its deepest nature, as divine as oneself) and a practical error (it generates karma that delays one's own liberation).

Jain ahimsa is the most extensive in scope of any tradition. It extends to: every human being, every animal (including insects), every plant (plants are one-sensed beings — they feel), every micro-organism (water contains living beings; air contains living beings; fire destroys living beings), and even beings in other planes of existence. No other tradition extends ahimsa as consistently or as completely.

The five forms of violence in Jain ethics: Sthula Himsa (Gross Violence — the direct, intentional taking of life); Sukshma Himsa (Subtle Violence — the indirect harm caused by one's lifestyle choices); Manasa Himsa (Mental Violence — violent thoughts toward any being — hatred, resentment, contempt); Vachana Himsa (Verbal Violence — harsh speech, insult, the use of language to wound); Kriya Himsa (Action-Based Violence — harm caused through one's work and economic activity). The Jain layperson's practice focuses heavily on minimizing subtle himsa — the indirect harm that is unavoidable in ordinary life.

## The Hierarchy of Sentient Beings

One of the most distinctive and most practically consequential aspects of Jain ethics is its detailed taxonomy of sentient beings — a rigorous classification of every type of living being according to the number of senses it possesses, from the most elementary (one-sensed, possessing only the sense of touch) to the most complex (five-sensed with mind, the category that includes human beings, animals, and divine beings). This taxonomy is not merely theoretical — it directly determines the ethical obligations of the Jain practitioner, who is required to minimize harm to beings at every level.

**ONE-SENSED BEINGS (Ekendriya):** Possessing only the sense of touch. This category encompasses an extraordinary range: earth beings (souls inhabiting soil, clay, dust), water beings (souls inhabiting water), fire beings (souls inhabiting fire and flame), air beings (souls inhabiting air and wind), and plant beings (every individual plant has a jiva, and in many cases each cell of a plant is understood as a separate one-sensed being). The Jain practitioner who steps on soil, drinks water, lights a fire, or eats a plant is unavoidably harming one-sensed beings — which is why the tradition focuses on minimizing rather than eliminating this harm for laypersons.

**TWO-SENSED BEINGS (Dvindriya):** Possessing touch and taste. Worms, leeches, certain shellfish, and similar organisms.

**THREE-SENSED BEINGS (Trindriya):** Possessing touch, taste, and smell. Ants, lice, and similar organisms.

**FOUR-SENSED BEINGS (Chaturindriya):** Possessing touch, taste, smell, and sight. Flies, mosquitoes, butterflies, and similar organisms.

**FIVE-SENSED BEINGS WITHOUT MIND (Panchendriya without manas):** Fish, amphibians, reptiles, birds, and most non-mammalian animals. Possessing all five senses but without the rational mind (manas) that enables deliberate ethical choice.

**FIVE-SENSED BEINGS WITH MIND (Panchendriya with manas — Sanjni):** Human beings, most mammals, divine beings, and hell-beings. This is the highest category — beings capable of rational thought, ethical choice, and therefore of the deliberate spiritual practice that leads to liberation. Only from this category can moksha be achieved — and of these, only human birth provides the specific conditions optimal for liberation.

The practical implication of this hierarchy: the Jain monk or nun who sweeps the ground before sitting or walking (to avoid crushing insects) is acknowledging the jiva of even the smallest being. The Jain practitioner who strains water before drinking is protecting water-beings. The Digambara monk who does not cook food (accepting only what is offered) is minimizing harm to fire-beings. The entire elaborate system of Jain practice flows from the recognition that every level of the hierarchy contains souls equal in their intrinsic divine nature to the practitioner's own.

# Anekantavada

## The Many-Sidedness of Truth

Anekantavada (literally "non-one-sidedness" or "many-sidedness of reality") is Jainism's philosophical doctrine that no single perspective can capture the whole truth about any reality — that every object of knowledge has infinite aspects, that every statement about reality is true only from a specific perspective (naya), and that the most honest and most accurate approach to knowledge involves the simultaneous acknowledgment of multiple valid perspectives rather than the insistence on any single perspective as exclusively true.

The most famous illustration: six blind scholars each touch a different part of an elephant. Each reports their finding: "It is a wall" (the side), "a rope" (the tail), "a tree trunk" (the leg), "a fan" (the ear), "a spear" (the tusk), "a snake" (the trunk). Each is accurate about their specific experience. Each is wrong to claim their experience is the complete truth. The whole elephant is most accurately described by holding all six perspectives simultaneously.

# Syadvada

## The Seven-Fold Logic

Anekantavada is formalized in Syadvada (conditional assertion — "syat" means "perhaps" or "in some respect") — a seven-fold logical system for making accurate statements about reality:

- 1. Syad Asti:** In some respect, it is (from one perspective, it exists or has this property)
- 2. Syad Nasti:** In some respect, it is not (from another perspective, it does not)
- 3. Syad Asti Nasti:** In some respect, it both is and is not (from different perspectives simultaneously)
- 4. Syad Avaktavya:** In some respect, it is indescribable (when both is and is not apply simultaneously, no single predication captures it)
- 5. Syad Asti Avaktavya:** In some respect, it is and is indescribable
- 6. Syad Nasti Avaktavya:** In some respect, it is not and is indescribable
- 7. Syad Asti Nasti Avaktavya:** In some respect, it both is and is not and is indescribable

Syadvada is not relativism — it is not saying that all claims are equally valid. It is saying that every claim is valid from its specific perspective and limited by that perspective, and that the honest thinker qualifies their statements with "in some respect" (syat) to acknowledge this limitation. This produces profound epistemic humility without collapsing into the position that no knowledge is possible.

# Nayavada

## The Doctrine of Partial Perspectives

Nayavada (the doctrine of nayas — partial perspectives or standpoints) is the epistemological complement to Anekantavada. Where Anekantavada addresses the nature of reality (it has infinite aspects), Nayavada addresses the nature of knowledge claims (every claim is made from a specific naya — a specific partial standpoint).

The Seven Nayas: Naigama Naya (Teleological Standpoint) — understanding something in terms of its purpose or goal. Sangraha Naya (Collective Standpoint) — understanding something in terms of its genus or collection. Vyavahara Naya (Practical Standpoint) — the conventional, practical understanding. Rjusutra Naya (Linear Standpoint) — understanding something in terms of only the present moment. Shabda Naya (Verbal Standpoint) — understanding something in terms of its grammatical or verbal characteristics. Samabhirudha Naya (Etymological Standpoint) — understanding something strictly by the etymology of the word used. Evambhuta Naya (Current Activity Standpoint) — understanding something only in terms of its actual current activity.

The practical lesson: every intellectual and spiritual disagreement can be analyzed through Nayavada — asking which naya each position is operating from and recognizing that both may be valid partial perspectives on a reality that neither fully captures.

# Aparigraha

## Non-Possession as Liberation from Wanting

Aparigraha (non-possession, non-attachment, non-acquisitiveness) is the fifth of the Jain great vows — and for the Jain tradition it is not merely a practical ethical constraint but a specific spiritual technology for loosening the karma-generating power of desire and attachment that most fundamentally chains the soul to the cycle of rebirth.

The Digambara expression of aparigraha in its most complete available form: the fully initiated Digambara monk owns nothing at all — not even clothing. The sky is their only covering. They eat from their cupped hands — not from a bowl, which would be a possession. They sleep on the floor of their host's home. They carry nothing, own nothing, have nothing to protect or lose. This is not poverty or deprivation in the ordinary sense: it is the complete freedom that comes from having eliminated the entire apparatus of wanting and having that defines ordinary human consciousness.

Aparigraha at different levels: For Digambara monks — complete non-possession, no clothing, no bowl, no possessions of any kind. For Shvetambara monks and nuns — minimal possessions: white robes, a begging bowl, a broom (to sweep away insects before sitting or walking), a muhapatti (mouth cloth to prevent insects from entering the mouth). For Jain laypersons — the practice of setting a specific limit on one's wealth accumulation (iccha parinam — limiting desires). Beyond that limit, the surplus is given away. The Jain community has historically been successful in trade and commerce — what aparigraha requires is non-attachment: owning things without being owned by them.

## The Five Great Vows (Mahavratas)

**AHIMSA (Non-Violence):** Non-harm to any living being in thought, word, and deed — in its full Jain scope extending to microorganisms. The most fundamental vow — all others support and enable it.

**SATYA (Truthfulness):** Speaking only what is true, beneficial, measured, and kind. The Jain understanding of truth connects to Anekantavada — truthful speech acknowledges the limitations of one's own perspective rather than claiming absolute certainty.

**ASTEYA (Non-Stealing):** Not taking what has not been given, including not accepting more resources than is appropriate. For monks: accepting food and shelter only when explicitly offered. For laypersons: honest dealing in all commercial and personal transactions.

**BRAHMACHARYA (Celibacy):** For monks and nuns, complete celibacy. For laypersons (in the anuvratas — lesser vows), fidelity within marriage and restraint outside it. The vow is understood not as a rejection of sexuality but as the channeling of the life force (virya) away from sense-gratification toward spiritual liberation.

**APARIGRAHA (Non-Possession):** The complete or limited renunciation of attachment to possessions, as appropriate to the practitioner's level of commitment. For Digambara monks, complete nudity. For Shvetambara monks, minimal possessions. For laypersons, the self-imposed limits of iccha parinam.



# The Three Jewels

## Samyak Jnana, Darshana, Charitra

The Jain path to liberation is organized around three interdependent dimensions (Ratnatraya — the Three Jewels), each necessary and none sufficient alone: Right Knowledge (Samyak Jnana), Right Perception/Faith (Samyak Darshana), and Right Conduct (Samyak Charitra). The Jain tradition is unusually explicit that all three must develop together — knowledge without conduct is hollow, conduct without knowledge is blind, and both without the underlying perceptual orientation are misdirected.

**SAMYAK DARSHANA (Right Perception/Faith):** The correct orientation of the soul — the fundamental disposition of the soul that has recognized the Jain path as the true path and committed to it. This is not blind faith but the specific recognition that the Jain account of reality (the jiva, the karma, the path to liberation) is correct. Samyak Darshana is considered the necessary first step — without the correct fundamental orientation, right knowledge and right conduct cannot develop properly.

**SAMYAK JNANA (Right Knowledge):** The specific knowledge of the soul, karma, the nature of reality, and the path to liberation. Jainism distinguishes five types of knowledge: Mati Jnana (sensory knowledge), Shruta Jnana (scriptural knowledge), Avadhi Jnana (clairvoyant knowledge, direct knowledge of material things at a distance), Manah Paryaya Jnana (direct knowledge of other minds), and Kevala Jnana (perfect omniscient knowledge — the state of the Tirthankaras and all liberated souls).

**SAMYAK CHARITRA (Right Conduct):** The specific ethical practice — the Five Great Vows for monks and nuns, the Twelve Vows for laypersons — through which karma is prevented from accumulating and existing karma is progressively eliminated. Right Conduct is the specific mechanism of liberation — the soul that perfectly practices the Five Great Vows is not generating new karma and is eliminating existing karma through the heat of tapas (austerity), until all karma is eliminated and moksha is achieved.

## The Digambara and Shvetambara Traditions

The two major sects of Jainism — Digambara ("sky-clad") and Shvetambara ("white-clad") — represent the most significant division within the tradition, dating to approximately 300 BCE (though the traditional accounts place it at the time of Chandragupta Maurya's reign). The split involved questions of monastic practice, the role of women in the tradition, and the authenticity of the scriptural canon.

### Digambara

Digambara monks practice complete nudity (sky-clad) as the fullest expression of aparigraha and ahimsa (even clothing involves possession and potentially harm to the beings in the fibers). They believe the original Agama scriptures of Mahavira were lost and do not accept the Shvetambara canonical texts. The Digambara tradition holds that women cannot attain moksha in female form — they must first be reborn as men. Digambara practice is more severe in its austerities and represents the stricter interpretation of the tradition. Concentrated in South and Central India (Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan).

### Shvetambara

Shvetambara monks and nuns wear simple white robes — rejecting the Digambara position that clothing constitutes a possession incompatible with liberation. They preserve a large body of canonical Agama texts which they believe to be authentic transmissions of Mahavira's teachings. The Shvetambara tradition holds that women can and do attain moksha in female form — and the 19th Tirthankara, Mallinath, is held by Shvetambaras to have been female. Concentrated in Gujarat, Rajasthan, and Maharashtra, and in the Jain diaspora communities of East Africa, the UK, and North America.

Despite these differences, both traditions share the fundamental Jain metaphysics, the three foundational principles (ahimsa, anekantavada, aparigraha), the five great vows (in the Digambara and Shvetambara forms), and the understanding of liberation as the complete elimination of karma. Both revere the same 24 Tirthankaras. The differences are in practice and in specific textual and theological claims, not in foundational philosophy.

# The Fourteen Gunasthanas

## Stages of Spiritual Development

The Gunasthanas (from Sanskrit: "stages of virtue/quality") are the 14 stages of spiritual development through which the soul progressively eliminates its karma and moves toward liberation. They provide the most detailed available map of the soul's ascent from total spiritual ignorance to omniscience and liberation.

- 1. Mithyadrishti (False Belief):** The state of the vast majority of beings — operating from false understanding of the soul, karma, and liberation.
- 2. Sasvadana (Slight Taste of Right Belief):** A brief transitional state.
- 3. Misra (Mixed State):** A state combining right and wrong belief, also transitional.
- 4. Avirata Samyak-drishti (Right Belief without Vows):** The soul has achieved correct understanding (samyak darshana) but has not yet taken the vows. This is the stage of the sincere Jain layperson who understands the path but is not yet committed to its full practice.
- 5. Desavirata (Partial Restraint):** The Jain layperson who has taken the lesser vows (anuvratas). Partial karma suppression.
- 6. Pramatta-sanyata (Restrained with Negligence):** The monk or nun who has taken the great vows but still experiences occasional lapses.
- 7. Apramatta-sanyata (Restrained without Negligence):** Perfect observance of the great vows, complete mindfulness. Karmic influx is at its minimum.
- 8. Apurvakarana (Unprecedented Activity):** The beginning of the destruction-suppression of the most fundamental karmas. First stage of advanced spiritual progress.
- 9. Anivrittakarana (Non-Turning Back):** The continuation of the destruction-suppression process.
- 10. Sukshma-samsparaya (Subtle Greed Remaining):** Only the subtlest form of deluding karma (subtle greed) remains.
- 11. Upashanta-kasaya (Suppressed Passions):** All passions are suppressed (but not eliminated). Can fall back.
- 12. Kshina-kasaya (Passions Destroyed):** All deluding karma is permanently destroyed. No return is possible. This stage produces what Jainism calls the "liberated while living" — Jivajivabhogama.
- 13. Sayogi-kevalin (Omniscient with Activity):** The Tirthankara who has achieved omniscience and continues to teach. No new karma can adhere, but the existing physical karma (determining the body's lifespan) runs its course.
- 14. Ayogi-kevalin (Omniscient without Activity):** The final stage — the soul ceases all activity (even breathing, because breathing harms air-beings), and in a matter of time perfectly calibrated to eliminate the last remaining karma, attains moksha.

# The Jain Monk and Nun

## Life of Total Commitment

The Jain monastic life is among the most demanding forms of religious practice in any tradition — a total commitment to the elimination of karma through the strict observance of the Five Great Vows, extended austerities, and a daily life that subordinates every consideration of personal comfort or convenience to the single goal of liberation.

The Shvetambara monk or nun's daily life: Rising before dawn, the monk or nun begins with meditation and study. They do not cook — they eat only what is offered by Jain laypersons who have specifically prepared extra food with the intent of offering it. The acceptance of food is itself a ritual — the monk approaches householders who indicate they are willing to give, receives the food in their hands or bowl, and accepts it only under specific conditions (the food must have been prepared without the intent of giving it to monks — to avoid the sin of killing on behalf of monks — though this rule is interpreted differently in different communities). They sweep the ground before sitting or walking (to avoid crushing insects). They strain water before drinking. They cover their mouths with a muhapatti. They do not use vehicles — they travel only on foot, and only within specific seasons. They do not bathe (bathing harms water-beings). They sleep on the floor.

The Digambara monk's life is even more severe: no clothing at all, eating once per day from cupped hands, traveling only within specific seasons, and observing a strict protocol of behavior toward laypersons who serve them. The Digambara monk is one of the most striking figures in Indian religious life — a naked figure of complete equanimity, indifferent to cold, heat, rain, insects, and the stares of passersby, moving through the world as a living embodiment of the principle that the soul requires nothing from the world.

# The Jain Layperson

## The Anuvrats — The Twelve Vows

The Jain layperson (shravaka — male; shravika — female) occupies an essential place in the tradition — they support the monastic community (providing food, shelter, and medical care), maintain Jain temples, sponsor sacred art and architecture, and practice a modified form of the Five Great Vows (the anuvratas — lesser vows) appropriate to a householder's life. The twelve vows of the Jain layperson are a complete ethical framework for living in the world while progressively loosening karma.

The Five Anuvratas (Lesser Vows): Ahimsa Anuvrat — avoiding gross violence (murder, hunting, deliberate cruelty) while acknowledging the unavoidable minor violences of daily life. Satya Anuvrat — truthfulness in personal and commercial dealings, avoiding harmful lies. Asteya Anuvrat — non-stealing, avoiding fraud and dishonest practices in trade. Brahmacharya Anuvrat — fidelity within marriage. Aparigraha Anuvrat — limiting one's possessions and desires to a specific self-defined level, donating the surplus.

The Jain layperson's dietary practice is one of the most demanding in any lay religious community: strict vegetarianism (avoiding all animal flesh, fish, and eggs), avoidance of root vegetables (whose harvest kills the entire plant — potatoes, carrots, onions, garlic, radishes), avoidance of eating after sunset (when insects are attracted to light and are more likely to enter food), straining of water before drinking, and (for the most committed) avoidance of green vegetables during specific sacred periods. This diet is one of the most consistent applications of ahimsa available in any lay religious tradition.

# Sallekhana

## The Sacred Fast unto Death

Sallekhana (also called Santhara — the sacred laying down of the body) is the Jain practice of the voluntary fast unto death — the deliberate, gradual, meditative withdrawal from food and water as a way of consciously completing the current life and discharging the maximum possible karma in the process of dying. It is the most distinctively Jain of all practices and the most frequently misunderstood.

What sallekhana is: a voluntary, gradual, meditative process of fasting undertaken only by someone who has reached the end of their productive life — when the body can no longer be used for spiritual practice, when illness or age has made continued productive living impossible, and when the practitioner has settled all outstanding obligations. What it is not: suicide in the ordinary sense. The tradition explicitly distinguishes sallekhana from suicide — suicide is motivated by passion (fear, despair, anger) and generates karma; sallekhana is motivated by the desire for liberation and performed in a state of equanimity and detachment that generates no karma.

The prerequisites: sallekhana requires the completion of all obligations (family, financial, social), the consent of the community (including the guru), the absence of fear, passion, or grief as motivating factors, and the genuine impossibility of continued productive spiritual practice. The practice: the process is gradual — weeks or months of progressive reduction in food and water intake, accompanied by continuous meditation, prayer, and the review and release of attachments. The practitioner is surrounded by the religious community throughout. Multiple Jain masters throughout history have undertaken sallekhana — it continues in the contemporary Jain community, though rarely.

# Paryushana and Samvatsari

## The Annual Sacred Period and Universal Forgiveness

Paryushana (in the Shvetambara tradition, eight days; in the Digambara tradition, ten days called Das Lakshana Parva) is the most sacred period in the Jain calendar — occurring in the month of Bhadrapada (August/September). It is a period of intensified spiritual practice: extended fasting, extended study, extended meditation — the most concentrated available period of spiritual labor in the Jain year.

The ten days of Digambara Das Lakshana focus on ten virtues: Uttama Kshama (Supreme Forgiveness), Uttama Mardava (Supreme Tenderness), Uttama Arjava (Supreme Straightforwardness), Uttama Shaucha (Supreme Purity), Uttama Satya (Supreme Truth), Uttama Samyam (Supreme Restraint), Uttama Tapa (Supreme Austerity), Uttama Tyaga (Supreme Renunciation), Uttama Akincanya (Supreme Non-Attachment), and Uttama Brahmacharya (Supreme Celibacy). Many Jains undertake extended fasts during Paryushana — from single-day fasts to eight-day or even month-long fasts.

The Samvatsari Pratikraman is the most important single ceremony of the Jain year — the comprehensive review of the past year's violations of the five vows, performed by both monks and laypersons. The Pratikraman is a specific ritual of confession and repentance that can last several hours. Samvatsari — the final day — is the day of universal forgiveness. Every Jain practitioner seeks forgiveness from every being they may have harmed in the past year, knowingly or unknowingly, and extends forgiveness to every being who may have harmed them. The formula: "Micchami Dukkadam" — "May all the evil I have done be undone. If I have offended you in any way — in thought, word, or deed — I ask for your forgiveness." The forgiveness sought is not only from humans — it is from every living being harmed in the past year.

# Jain Sacred Texts

## The Agamas

The Jain scriptural canon is called the Agamas — texts understood to preserve the teachings of Mahavira as recorded and transmitted by his immediate disciples (Ganadharas). The Shvetambara tradition preserves a canon of 45 Agamas (of an original 12 major texts called Angas, plus supplementary texts), which they believe to be authentic transmissions of Mahavira's teachings, though they acknowledge that some texts were lost and others were reconstructed after a period of oral transmission. The Digambara tradition holds that the original 12 Angas were entirely lost after a period of famine and dispersal of the monastic community, and therefore does not accept the Shvetambara canon as authoritative.

Key Jain texts: The Acaranga Sutra (the oldest surviving Jain text — describing Mahavira's life, particularly the period of his renunciation and austerities). The Suttrakritanga (a foundational Shvetambara text addressing the relationship of Jainism to other philosophical positions). The Tattvartha Sutra (written by Umasvati, approximately 2nd-5th century CE — a comprehensive philosophical synthesis accepted by both Digambara and Shvetambara traditions as authoritative; it is the single most important Jain philosophical text). The Kalpa Sutra (a Shvetambara text containing the biographies of Mahavira and other Tirthankaras; read during Paryushana).

Both traditions also draw on an extensive secondary literature: commentaries (bhashyas), philosophical texts (especially the works of Kundakunda, a revered Digambara teacher of the 1st-3rd centuries CE), and a vast tradition of narrative literature (Jain versions of major Indian stories, Jain cosmological texts, Jain ethical manuals). The Jain tradition has produced one of the most extensive bodies of philosophical literature in any Indian tradition, covering logic, epistemology, ethics, cosmology, and spiritual practice in extraordinary detail.



# Jain Cosmology

## The Universe Without a Creator

Jain cosmology is one of the most detailed and most distinctive in any tradition — and its most defining characteristic is the one it shares with Buddhism and with modern scientific cosmology: there is no creator God. The universe is eternal, uncreated, and self-regulating. The Tirthankaras do not create or sustain the universe; they have transcended it. The universe operates according to its own natural laws (the interactions of jivas and ajivas, the mechanics of karma) without requiring a divine superintendent.

The Jain universe is shaped like a cosmic being standing with their feet apart — broader at the middle and narrower at top and bottom. It is finite but vast. Three realms: Adholoka (Lower World) — seven levels of infernal regions (narakas) where souls experiencing the consequences of extreme negative karma are born; Madhyaloka (Middle World) — where human beings, animals, and plants exist; the human realm is the only realm from which liberation is possible; Urdhvaloka (Upper World) — multiple levels of celestial realms where divine beings exist in various degrees of bliss. Above all the celestial realms is the Siddha Loka — the crescent-shaped realm at the very top of the universe, the dwelling place of the liberated souls (Siddhas) who remain here in infinite bliss and omniscience forever.

The Cosmic Cycles: Time operates in infinite cycles of ascent (utsarpini) and descent (avasarpini), each lasting billions of years. We are currently in a descending half-cycle — a period in which the moral and spiritual condition of the world gradually deteriorates. The last Tirthankara of this cycle, Mahavira, appeared near the beginning of this descending half; no more Tirthankaras will appear until the next ascending half-cycle.

## Jain Sacred Art and Architecture

Jain sacred architecture is among the most extraordinary in the world — characterized by an intensity of artistic labor that directly expresses the Jain understanding of the sacred as worthy of the most complete possible human devotion. The tradition's most famous sites are considered among the finest examples of temple architecture and sculptural art in human history.

**PALITANA (Shatrunjaya Hill, Gujarat):** The most sacred Jain pilgrimage site — a hilltop complex containing approximately 900 marble temples built over 900 years (from the 11th century onwards). Reaching Palitana requires climbing approximately 3,500-3,800 stone steps barefoot (shoes are left at the base). No one may stay overnight on the hill — not even the priests — as the site is understood to be the exclusive domain of the divine beings during the night. The primary temple is dedicated to Rishabhanatha (Adinath), the first Tirthankara. The sight of 900 temples gleaming white on a hilltop is one of the most visually overwhelming experiences in Indian sacred life.

**DILWARA TEMPLES (Mount Abu, Rajasthan):** A group of five marble temples built between the 11th and 13th centuries, widely considered among the finest examples of marble craftsmanship in human history. The stone looks like lace — intricate carvings covering every surface, with the stone so finely worked in some areas that it is translucent. The Vimala Vasahi (1031 CE) and the Luna Vasahi (1230 CE) are the most celebrated. Photography is not permitted inside — the intention is that the experience must be held in the memory, not the camera.

**RANAKPUR (Pali District, Rajasthan):** The Chaumukha temple (1438 CE), dedicated to Adinath — a vast complex of 29 halls supported by 1,444 intricately carved marble pillars, each one uniquely different from every other. The play of light through the carved pillars throughout the day produces an ever-changing visual experience. The mathematical regularity of the structure combined with the organic variety of the individual pillars is a material expression of *anekantavada* — infinite variation within a single ordered reality.

**SHRAVANABELAGOLA (Karnataka):** Home to the 57-foot (17-meter) monolithic statue of Lord Bahubali (Gomateshwara), carved from a single rock in 981 CE. The statue — the largest monolithic statue in the world — depicts Bahubali, the son of Rishabhanatha (the first Tirthankara), who stood in meditation so long that vines grew around his legs and anthill colonies formed at his feet. Every 12 years the Mahamastakabhisheka festival takes place, in which thousands of devotees pour milk, saffron, and flowers over the statue from scaffolding above its head — one of the most spectacular religious ceremonies in India (next celebration: 2030).

**SHIKHARJI / PARASNATH HILL (Jharkhand):** The holiest Jain mountain — where 20 of the 24 Tirthankaras are traditionally understood to have attained liberation. The mountain is sacred as a concentrated site of *moksha*, and the pilgrimage circuit (*parikrama*) of approximately 54 km around the hill is considered the most meritorious Jain pilgrimage.

## Gandhi and Jain Influence on the World

Mohandas Gandhi's explicit acknowledgment of Jain influence on his philosophy of nonviolent resistance (satyagraha) makes Jainism the tradition with arguably the most consequential direct influence on 20th-century history of any ancient tradition. Through Gandhi, Jain ahimsa influenced the Indian independence movement, and through Gandhi's documented influence on Martin Luther King Jr. and Nelson Mandela, Jain ahimsa influenced the American civil rights movement and the anti-apartheid movement in South Africa.

Rajchandra Raychandbhai (Shrimad Rajchandra, 1867-1901): Gandhi's most important spiritual teacher was a Jain scholar and businessman. Gandhi wrote: "Of all the people who influenced me, Raychandbhai influenced me more than anyone else." Gandhi took Jain ahimsa and developed it into satyagraha — the force of truth, the method of nonviolent resistance. The direct line from Jain ahimsa through Gandhi's satyagraha to King's nonviolent civil rights strategy to Mandela's negotiated transition is one of the most significant ethical transmission chains in modern history.

Gandhi's deliberate simplicity — the homespun cloth, the minimal possessions, the self-limitation of wants — is directly influenced by Jain aparigraha. His ashram life embodied Jain principles in a political and social context. Gandhi's respect for all religious traditions — his insistence that truth is not owned by any single tradition — reflects the influence of Jain anekantavada. His prayer meetings included hymns from Hindu, Muslim, Christian, and Sikh traditions.

# The Haligricity Lens

## Anekantavada and Ahimsa as Practice

Jainism's contribution to Haligricity is philosophically foundational and practically radical. Anekantavada provides the most formally complete philosophical framework for the synthesis approach that Haligricity employs; ahimsa provides the ethical orientation through which the Haligric practitioner relates to every tradition in the library.

Every guide in the Haligricity library is an act of anekantavada. The recognition that the Yoruba understanding of Ashe and the Zoroastrian understanding of Asha and the Chinese understanding of Qi and the Druidic understanding of Nwyfre are all partial and valid perspectives on the same sacred reality — and that holding them simultaneously produces a more complete picture than any single perspective — is Syadvada applied to the world's sacred traditions. The "syat" (in some respect, perhaps) that qualifies every Jain philosophical statement is the epistemic humility that every sincere engagement with another tradition requires.

Jain ahimsa, applied to the practitioner's relationship with other sacred traditions, means: no tradition is dismissed, diminished, distorted, or treated as inferior to one's own primary tradition. Each is approached with the same respect and care one would bring to a living being deserving of non-harm. This is the ethical foundation of Haligricity's synthesis: not merely tolerance or curiosity, but the specific active commitment to non-harm in every engagement with every tradition's specific sacred content.

"Micchami Dukkadam. May all the evil I have done be undone." Every time Haligricity engages with a tradition — every guide in this library — the Jain principle of ahimsa and anekantavada is operative: the commitment not to harm the tradition through misrepresentation, not to appropriate its most sacred elements without acknowledgment, not to flatten its complexity into the convenient, and to hold its specific partial truth with the genuine epistemic humility that Syadvada demands. Grand Rising.

*"Micchami Dukkadam.  
May all the evil I have done be undone."*

— The Jain formula of universal forgiveness, spoken on Samvatsari

Every living being carries a divine soul. The jiva of the microorganism crushed underfoot is, in its intrinsic nature, equal to the jiva of the Tirthankara. Ahimsa is the practical application of this recognition. Anekantavada is its epistemological companion — the recognition that no single perspective, including mine, captures the whole. These two together are among the most precise available tools for the Haligric practitioner navigating a library of sacred traditions whose combined truth is greater than any one of them. Grand Rising.